though, to see how even veteran journalists were fawning over Shah. ‘Should I get you some extra ketchup, sir?’ one of them asked, while the famished campaign manager cleaned up a plate of cheese sandwiches.

Shah was taking no chances even after the spectacular success of the nomination roadshow. He had made Varanasi his base for managing the entire eastern UP campaign in the last stretch. One day, he received reports that the party workers had become complacent about victory and weren’t working hard enough. At 10 p.m. all local leaders were called and warned, ‘From tomorrow, I want to see all of you out on the road, no excuses.’ Shah is a great believer in the power of a door-to-door campaign in true RSS volunteer-style. Each leader was told to ensure that no house in their area was missed.

Kejriwal, by contrast, did not have the money power—certainly nothing to match the BJP election machine. Nor, this time, the media support. He had arrived in Varanasi by train in mid-April and set about trying to climb the steepest mountain of his political career. Just before arriving in Varanasi, Kejriwal had also travelled to Gujarat, where in a show of political bravado, he had marched almost up to Modi’s residence in Gandhinagar, apparently to seek an appointment. Clashes with BJP workers, detentions and acts of stoning had met him in Gujarat, where armed with a notepad he was seen jotting down the number of dysfunctional schools and badly staffed clinics to arrive at his conclusion of a non-existent Gujarat model of development. Kejriwal’s Gujarat trip may not have yielded political gain on the ground but was a symbolic show of strength—he was unafraid to enter the lion’s den.

In Varanasi, Kejriwal did manage to create a stir initially—with his campaign gaining some visibility after his supporters took on the BJP on the streets—but it was soon obvious that Varanasi was not Delhi. Many of his volunteers had come from other states. They were simply not familiar with the narrow by-lanes of this city where every alley has a different character. ‘I think we underestimated the scale of what we were up against,’ confessed an AAP leader.